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Learning the Nuts and Bolts

The brokerage firm for which I was working was not as inconsequential as I had initially thought. It was just that the owner liked to keep a low profile. And, exactly for this reason, some corporations and institutions preferred to deal with him. I worked in the back office, filling the share transfer deeds for buying clients and following up on deliveries to be made by selling clients. This way, I got to learn exactly who was selling or buying what shares. In the shallow market of those days, this information was valuable, since some of our clients were important players in the market.

My salary as a back office clerk was Rs 2,000 a month, about the same that I earned at my previous job. But I had no doubt that I had chosen the right path, even if it did call for a bit of luck to hit the first milestone I had set for myself.

My job was monotonous, but I did it with utmost dedication as I saw it as a stepping stone to the trading ring where the real action lay. After office hours, I would attempt to make friends with my counterparts in some of the other important brokerage firms. Though I was a reserved person, I began to realize the importance of being well networked, even if I was starting small.

My hard work was not lost on the owner of the firm, and he felt I could be used better than just as a paper sorter at the back office. A broker could have seven of his dealers in the trading ring, apart from himself. Orders placed by clients over the telephone to the broker's office would be conveyed to the dealers on the trading floor, who would then execute the